

Session 20: The Snake in Genesis and Beyond

Key Takeaways

- The snake comes first but is made subject to the human. This sets up the repeated theme of the latecomer being favored, leading to jealousy and strife.
- Textual details and themes in Genesis and the rest of the Hebrew Bible indicate that the snake is a spiritual being.
- The failure of the snake and humanity in the garden sets up a theme of human and spiritual rebellion that continues throughout Scripture.

The Pattern of Sibling Rivalry in Genesis

SIBLING RIVALRY

	<u>FIRST BORN</u>	<u>LATE COMER</u>
	CAIN	ABEL
	SARAH	HAGAR
	ISHMAEL	ISAAC
	ESAU	JACOB & MOM
	ALL BROTHERS	JOSEPH
GEN. 1	LAND CREATURES	HUMANS

Sibling Rivalry. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

The Identity of the Snake in the Hebrew Bible

Genesis 3:1 Instructor's Translation

Now the snake (Heb. *nakhash* /נחש) was more shrewd than any living creature of the field which the LORD God had made.

The image of the snake as a “living creature of the field” is a dense narrative image that invites the reader to ponder it from many angles. Here are some of the layers of meaning that seem intended by the author’s choice of the snake as the tempter.

1. The Snake Among the Animals of Genesis 1

On day six of Genesis 1, God populates the dry land with creatures—first the animals and then humanity.

Genesis 1:24-26 NASB*

²⁴ And God said, “Let the land bring forth **living creatures** after their kind: cattle and **creeping things** and beasts of the land after their kind”; and it was so. ²⁵ God made the **living creatures** of the land after their kind, and the cattle after their kind, and everything that **creeps on the ground** after its kind; and God saw that it was good. ²⁶ And God said, “Let us make **human** in our image, according to our likeness; and let them rule over the fish of the sea and over the birds of the sky and over the cattle and over all the earth, and over **every creeping thing** that creeps on the earth.”

*Kew Words Adapted by Teacher

Notice the animals are called “the living creatures” (Heb. *khayyot* /חיות) and specified by rough categories: domesticated animals, creepers (the wild ones that run and hide), and the wild beasts.

Humans are the last thing to be created in Genesis 1, yet they are the ones elevated to rule over all creation: the sea, the sky, and the land creatures. This establishes a major design pattern in the biblical story: God’s elevation of the latecomer to a role of honor above the ones who came before.

In the book of Genesis, the theme of the latecomer’s elevation often focuses on the jealousy and anger of the elder. Think of Cain and Abel, or Jacob and Esau (“the older will serve the younger,” (Gen. 25:23), or of Joseph’s older brothers who hate him because he had a dream where he ruled over them (Gen. 37:1-11). Or think of David’s jealous older brothers who were not chosen to be king (1 Sam. 16-17), and so on.

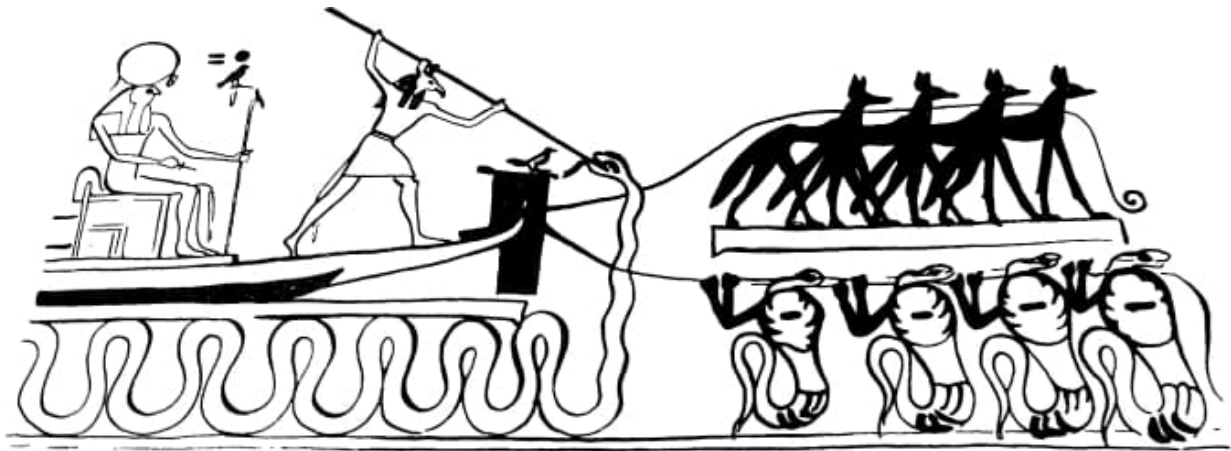
When you come to Genesis 3 after considering this pattern throughout the Hebrew Bible, you’re prompted to notice the beasts of day six, who are created first yet summoned to come under the rule of humans who came second. Will any of them be like Cain or Esau or Joseph’s brothers and resent being ruled by a creature who has only come to the dry land after them?

2. The Snake as a Symbol of Disorder and Sorcery

In the ancient Near East, snakes were powerful symbols of chaos creatures, creatures that don’t properly belong to the divinely ordered world. The snake is both a water and land creature, yet it has no legs, making it out of place on the dry land. But it also doesn’t have fins, making it also out of place in the water.

This “out of order” nature of the snake is why it is included among the ritually impure animals in Israel’s Kosher food laws (Lev. 11:42). Animals that do not properly fit in their category are liminal and belong to the non-ordered realm.

Snakes were potent symbols of immortality (rebirth through shedding of skin), death (poisonous bite), and the underworld realm of the dead (they crawl on the ground and descend into holes). To have mastery of snakes was to be a master of death. This explains the pervasive snake imagery in Egyptian royal art.



Keel, Othmar (1997). "Figure 55" (p. 55). *Symbolism of the Biblical World: Ancient Near Eastern Iconography and the Book of Psalms*. Eisenbrauns.

Image Description: The sun god Re is pulled through the underworld sea at night. The god Seth spears and defeats the death god Apophis (a snake), while the boat is pulled by subjugated night demons (jackals and snakes).



Jensen, Tom. *Gilgamesh Cylinder Seal Impression Tablet 11 Photo*. The Schoyen Collection. [Medium](#)

"This plant ... is the 'Plant of Heartbeat,' with it a man can regain his vigour ... 'Its name shall be "Old Man Grown Young," I will eat it myself, and be again as I was in my youth!' ... Gilgamesh found a pool whose water was cool, down he went into it, to bathe in the water. Of the plant's fragrance a snake caught scent, came up [in silence], and carried off the plant. As it turned away it shed its skin. Then Gilgamesh sat down and wept, down his cheeks the tears were coursing."

Dalley, Stephanie (2006). [Myths from Mesopotamia: Creation, the Flood, Gilgamesh, and Others](#). Oxford University Press.

“Throughout the ancient world, [the serpent] was endowed with divine or semidivine qualities; it was venerated as an emblem of health, fertility, immortality, occult wisdom, and chaotic evil; and it was often worshipped. The serpent played a significant role in the mythology, the religious symbolism, and the cults of the ancient Near East.”

Sarna, Nahum (2001). [*The JPS Torah Commentary: Genesis*](#). Jewish Publication Society.

The word *nakhash* (נָחָשׁ) also contains a double meaning because it is also the word for sorcery or divination.

Deuteronomy 18:9-11 NIV

⁹ When you enter the land the LORD your God is giving you, do not learn to imitate the detestable ways of the nations there. ¹⁰ Let no one be found among you who sacrifices their son or daughter in the fire, who practices divination (*nakhash*) or sorcery, interprets omens, engages in witchcraft, ¹¹ or casts spells, or who is a medium or spiritist or who consults the dead.

2 Kings 21:5-6 NIV*

⁵ In the two courts of the temple of the LORD, [Manasseh] built altars to all the starry hosts. ⁶ He sacrificed his own son in the fire, practiced divination (*nakhash*), sought omens, and consulted mediums and spiritists. He did much evil in the eyes of the LORD, arousing his anger.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

2 Kings 17:16-17 NIV*

¹⁶ They forsook all the commands of the LORD their God and made for themselves two idols cast in the shape of calves, and an Asherah pole. They bowed down to all the starry hosts, and they worshiped Baal. ¹⁷ They sacrificed their sons and daughters in the fire. They practiced divination (*nakhash*) and sought omens and sold themselves to do evil in the eyes of the LORD, arousing his anger.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

3. The Snake as a Figure in the Heavenly Throne Room

The garden of Eden is a high mountain garden-temple where Heaven and its creatures overlap with the Earth and its creatures. Here are several observations that lead us to this conclusion.

- The garden is the source of a single river that leaves the garden and divides into four rivers that water the main regions of the biblical world (see [Gen. 2:8-14](#)). This has a fairly obvious implication; the garden of Eden is portrayed as the highest place on the dry land.
- Eden is described as the host land of the ultimate garden-temple. It's a land of gold, fruit trees, precious gems, and abundance ([Gen. 2:9-14](#)). These are precisely the images and materials used in the construction of the tabernacle ([Exod. 25:1-31:18](#)) and the temple in Jerusalem ([1 Kgs. 6:1-7:51](#)).
- The Heaven and Earth Eden temple is the same place Israel's prophets saw in their visions ([Isa. 6:1-13](#); [1 Kgs. 22:1-53](#); [Ezek. 1:1-28](#)), a place where God's heavenly presence overlaps with Earth. We're told that there are cherubim in this garden ([Gen. 3:22-24](#))([Gen. 3:22-24](#)), just like the ones that populate God's throne room ([Ezek. 10:1-15](#)).

All of this leads the reader to expect Adam and Eve to live together in the garden with spiritual beings of the hybrid animal variety. So when a talking snake appears in Genesis 3, we have a category for this kind of creature. Let's look at the statement where the snake is introduced.

Genesis 3:1 NASB*

Now the snake (Heb. *nakhash* / נחש) was more shrewd than any beast of the field which the LORD God had made. And he said to the woman, "Indeed, has God said, 'You shall not eat from any tree of the garden'?"

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

This comment suggests there is more to this snake than just an animal. For starters, it can talk! The phrase "more shrewd than any beast of the field" could mean that the snake belongs to the beasts of the field and is more sly than the rest. Or it could also mean that it isn't technically a beast of the field; rather, it's a different kind of creature that is simply more shrewd than any kind of beast. With either interpretation, we can conclude that this is not an average snake!

The snake also appears to have knowledge of God's decisions and purposes ("God knows that in the day you eat [the fruit] you will be like divine beings, knowing good and bad." Gen. 3:5).

If we fast forward to the end of the Eden narrative, when God curses the snake in Genesis 3:14, we'll find another interesting statement about the nature of the snake.

Genesis 3:14 NASB

Because you have done this,
cursed are you more than all cattle,
and more than every beast of the field;
on your belly you will go,
and dust you will eat
all the days of your life.

If it was a normal snake, wouldn't it already crawl in the dust on its belly? Why does God say the snake's future state will be to go in the dust if it already crawls on the ground? This statement could mean that the snake that approached the humans wasn't on the ground.

This puzzling image of a snake that doesn't crawl on the ground finds its confirmation much later in the biblical story. When the prophet Isaiah has a vision of God's heavenly throne room, he sees heavenly creatures surrounding God's throne. In Ezekiel's visions of the same space, these beings are called "cherubim" and "living creatures," but Isaiah calls them "seraphim" (Heb. שרפים).

Isaiah 6:1-3 NASB

¹ In the year of King Uzziah's death I saw the Lord sitting on a throne, lofty and exalted, with the train of his robe filling the temple. ² **Seraphim** stood above him, **each having six wings**: with two he covered his face, and with two he covered his feet, and with two he flew. ³ And one called out to another and said, "Holy, Holy, Holy, is the LORD of hosts, the whole earth is full of his glory!"

This is the only place in the entire Bible where the heavenly throne room creatures are called *seraphim*. All modern English translations leave this word untranslated, which is strange, because it is a normal Hebrew

word for venomous snake.

Numbers 21:6 NASB*

Yahweh sent snakes (Heb. *nakhashim*, plural noun), **venomous snakes** (Heb. *seraphim*, plural noun) among the people, and they bit the people.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Deuteronomy 8:15 NASB*

Yahweh led you in the great and terrifying wilderness, of the snake, the **venomous snake** (Heb. *seraph*, singular noun).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Later in the book of Isaiah, the prophet describes the ruler of Babylon as a “snake” (Heb. *nakhash*) and a “flying snake” (Heb. *saraph me’opheph*). This appears in the same section as Isaiah’s accusation against the ruler of Babylon, which refers both to the human king of Babylon and a spiritual power that lurks behind Babylon.

Flying snakes were a common religious icon in the ancient Near East, and images of them have even been found in ancient Israelite art. For examples, see the images below.



Left image: Keel, Othmar (1977). *Jahwe-Visionen und Siegelkunst: Eine neue Deutung der Majestätsschilderungen in Jes 6, Ez 1 und 10 und Sach 4* (Stuttgarter Bibelstudien) (German Edition). Verlag Katholisches Bibelwerk. Middle and right image: Deutsch, Robert (2012). “Six Hebrew Fiscal Bullae from the Time of Hezekiah.” Soc. of Biblical Literature.

Another important instance is in the scroll of Ezekiel. The prophet Ezekiel looks out at Tyre (a powerful seaside kingdom of his day) and accuses its leader of acting like an ancient spiritual rebel. Ezekiel first accuses Tyre’s king of claiming to be a deity.

Ezekiel 28:6-9 NASB*

⁶ Therefore thus says the Lord God,
“Because you have made your heart like the heart of God,
⁷ therefore, behold, I will bring strangers upon you,

the most ruthless of the nations.

And they will draw their swords against the **beauty of your wisdom** and defile **your splendor**.

⁸ They will bring you **down to the pit**,
and you will die the death of those who are slain in the heart of the seas.

⁹ Will you still say, **'I am an elohim,'**
in the presence of your slayer, though **you are a human and not elohim**,
in the hands of those who wound you?"

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Ezekiel then likens the king of Tyre to an ancient spiritual rebel who inhabited Eden.

Ezekiel 28:12-17 NIV

¹² Son of man, take up a lament concerning the king of Tyre and say to him:
"This is what the Sovereign LORD says:

**'You were the seal of perfection,
full of wisdom and perfect in beauty.**

¹³ **You were in Eden,
the garden of God;**

every precious stone adorned you:
carnelian, chrysolite and emerald, topaz, onyx and jasper,
lapis lazuli, turquoise and beryl.

Your settings and mountings were made of gold;
on the day you were created they were prepared.

¹⁴ **You were anointed as a covering cherub**, for so I ordained you.

You were on the holy mount of God;
you walked among the fiery stones.

¹⁵ You were blameless in your ways
from the day you were created
till wickedness was found in you.

¹⁶ Through your widespread trade
you were filled with violence, and you sinned.

**So I drove you in disgrace from the mount of God,
and I expelled you, guardian cherub,**
from among the fiery stones.

¹⁷ Your heart became proud
on account of your beauty,
and you corrupted your wisdom because of your splendor."

Ezekiel provides us with the earliest interpretation of the Genesis 3 snake in the Bible. The snake is understood to be a spiritual being, one of the winged throne guardians, a "living creature" (*cherubim*) in the garden temple. But as we learned from the "last will be first" design pattern in Genesis, it seems that we're meant to infer that this snake resented coming under the authority of the human creatures whose origins were of dirt. And so this glorious creature misused its honored place of God-given authority and rebelled by seducing the

humans into misusing their authority in the same way. In this way, the snake represents a spiritual rebellion that coincides with the earthly rebellion of the humans. Genesis 3 portrays the fall of humanity and the fall of the spiritual rebel.

“How are we supposed to understand the serpent’s function in the story? On the one hand the author wants to convey the idea of an actual snake, one of the animals Yahweh had made. But it is precisely this referential comment that raises a clear tension: What about this snake’s ability to speak? And how is it that the snake is more shrewd and knowledgeable than humans? If the text intentionally raises such questions and then leaves them unanswered, it’s clear that this is a purposeful and deliberate means of creating a mystery. More than that, the narrative wants to present the temptation’s power and effectiveness as resting on this mysterious nature. Therefore, we may not expect the text to satisfy our curiosity. It seeks to not only communicate the scene from Eve’s point of view, but also seeks to evoke curiosity in the reader as a literary device to draw them into the narrative. The author wants the readers to experience the power and elusiveness of the snake ‘first hand,’ as it were.”

Emmrich, Martin (2001). “The Temptation Narrative in Genesis as a Prelude to the Pentateuch and History of Israel”. *The Evangelical Quarterly*.

Recommended Resource

For more discussion of Genesis 3 as the fall narrative of humanity and the snake, check out Seth Postell’s book, [Adam as Israel: Genesis 1-3 as the Introduction to the Torah and Tanakh, chapter 6](#).

Reflection Question

Who was created last in Genesis 1, humans or animals? What about in Genesis 2? Was it the animals or the woman?